

PARK in a TRUCK

ORGANIZE

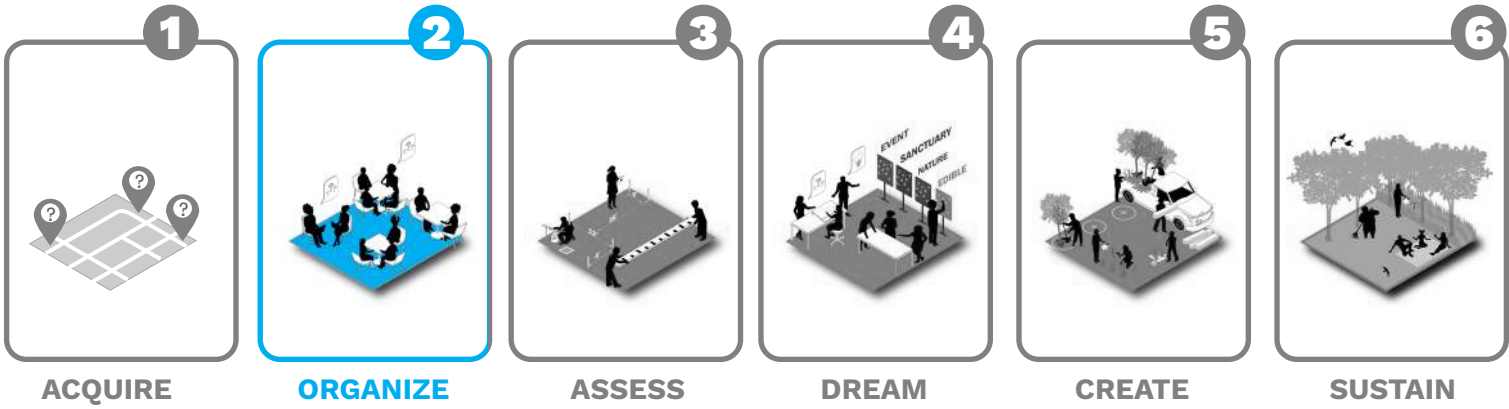
W O R K B O O K



A do-it-yourself toolkit for neighborhood parks

The Landscape Architecture Program +
The Lab for Social and Urban Innovation
Thomas Jefferson University
Philadelphia, PA

Welcome to the Organize Workbook! This booklet assumes you have read the Park in a Truck Toolkit, completed Workbook 1, and are ready to organize your park group.



DOWNLOAD
ACQUIRE
WORKBOOK

DOWNLOAD
ASSESS
WORKBOOK

DOWNLOAD
DREAM
WORKBOOK

DOWNLOAD
CREATE
WORKBOOK

DOWNLOAD
THE SUSTAIN
WORKBOOK

ORGANIZE CONTENTS



- OVERVIEW
- COMMUNITY ASSETS
- NEIGHBORHOOD ASSETS
- PARK COMMITTEE CHECKLIST

How do you rally a community and neighborhood to work together to build a park? This workbook will help you create a well-rounded park committee by building on your community’s existing assets and strengths. Yes, it takes a village!



OVERVIEW

At the core of every successful Park project is a diverse and talented group of committed residents working together as a team. This Park Committee will lead your park creation effort. Ideally, these volunteers represent the various groups who will use the park—young, old, different racial and ethnic groups, professional, working class, homeowners and renters. They should look like your community. Additionally, think about their talents. Having people with different talents and experience—builders, legal knowledge, political connections, community organizers, clergy, social butterflies, etc.—will increase your chances of success.

Once formed, the committee’s first task is to identify and document what is unique about your neighborhood and park site.

IDENTIFYING COMMUNITY ASSETS

Now let’s think about the people in your neighborhood and their unique skill sets—do they like to cook? Organize events? Garden? Love history and could do research on the neighborhood? All of these can translate into valuable and useful skills to help get the park designed, built and maintained. You just need to list them so you know who you might tap to help with different jobs in the park process.

Below is a checklist to help you identify community assets. At your first community meeting, you should ask folks to write down their related skills on the sign-up sheet.

INDIVIDUAL SKILL LIST

☐	Project Manager to oversee building of park	
☐	Organizing the park/design build process	
☐	Carpentry	
☐	Masonry	
☐	Gardening/maintenance for park	
☐	Planting trees,shrubs,flowers	
☐	Helping to build the park	
☐	Fundraising	
☐	Bookkeeping	
☐	Babysitting	
☐	Food for meetings/building park	
☐	Artist	
☐	Photography	
☐	Music for park build days- DJ	
☐	Media outreach- facebook, instagram, twitter	
☐	History Buffs	
☐	Other	

IDENTIFYING COMMUNITY ASSETS

Next list all citizen and local associations that might be partners and provide support both monetary and in-kind or where you might purchase locally for the park materials:

CITIZENS ASSOCIATIONS ASSET LIST

● Churches

● Block Captains

● Registered Community Organizations

● Community Design Collabarative

● Cultural Groups

● Other

LOCAL INSTITUTIONS

● Businesses

● Schools

● Parks + Habitat areas

● Libraries

● Hospitals

● Universities + Colleges

● Other

NEIGHBORHOOD ASSETS

Another critical step in your park-building journey is identifying the unique features of your neighborhood and park site. Take time to stop and look for the abundance of clues that makes your neighborhood special in its own way. Every neighborhood has inherent value born of its own history and culture. Identifying and tapping into these assets will strengthen your park project and inspire community ownership.

So how do we identify assets and strengths? Think about your neighborhood and the history and culture—what are the special places? Where do people like to congregate? Were there important events that happened in your neighborhood? What once stood where your park is located?

NEIGHBORHOOD PHYSICAL ASSETS

☐

Places where people like to meet

☐

Important events in the neighborhood

☐

Important buildings

☐

Special clubs

☐

Landmarks

☐

Streetscapes

☐

Parks

☐

Other types of open space

☐

Murals

☐

History

☐

Unique aspects of your neighborhood

☐

Other

ORGANIZE A MEETING

Holding a public meeting can be a really good way of building a campaign or getting more people involved in your group. Here are a few ideas to help your community group organize a meeting that is interesting, accessible and runs smoothly.

KEEP IT SIMPLE

Running a discussion with members of the public, particularly if a lot of people show up, can be a bit daunting. Don't try to cram in too much. A public meeting is not the place to have complicated discussions about the structure of your group or the nitty gritty of your everyday organizing. Instead, use it as a way to share basic information about what you want to do, encourage others to share their opinions and ideas, and gain contact details of people who may wish to be involved in the future.

PUBLICIZE IT WELL

The design of your publicity material is important. Think about who you are hoping to attract to the meeting, and make sure your poster or leaflet will catch their eye. Give them a reason to come along to your meeting. Make sure the date, time and place of the meeting are clearly shown on the leaflet, and that it's clear what the meeting is about. Just as the plan for your meeting should be simple, the topic that you publicize should be simple and clear too. You might do the following to advertise:

- Flyers
- Posters
- Facebook posting
- Twitter announcement
- Advertise in local community newsletter or local paper

OFFER AN INCENTIVE

For some it is a big effort to arrange childcare or transport, so it's a good idea to offer an extra incentive if possible. This could simply be free refreshments, or perhaps a video or speaker about something to do with the group's aims or activity. You can even offer childcare with student volunteers.

THINK ABOUT THE AGENDA

If people take the time to come to a public meeting, it is because they really care about the topic being discussed. Although it is important to give people a chance to have their say, it is also your job to make sure that the meeting sticks to the topic. A good way of doing this is to prepare an agenda in advance. What you include in this will depend on the purpose and expected size of the meeting, but here are some ideas you could use:

- Welcome and introductions
- Explain who called the meeting and why
- Outline why the meeting has been called: to build a park, solicit help with building the park, park ambassadors etc.
- Consider asking someone who has been through the process of designing and building a park to share their insights. But keep it brief. This first meeting shouldn't be a lecture.
- Ask the Park in a Truck team at Jefferson University to provide a speaker.

OPPORTUNITY FOR PEOPLE TO SHARE INFORMATION AND OPINIONS

There may be opposition to a park – let people have a chance to air their views. It's important to build consensus on the possible park location. Public meetings can be good opportunities to come up with initial ideas about action that could be taken in the future. Allow some opportunity for people to share their ideas, but don't allow the meeting to get bogged down in nitty gritty details. Make a note of people's ideas.

WHAT WILL HAPPEN NEXT

Summarize the ideas that have been raised. If the meeting is small, this might be an opportunity to reach decisions about what action is actually going to be taken. Be sure to include discussion of what practical tasks need to be done, and who is going to do them.

CHAIRING THE MEETING

If your group has called the meeting, people will be expecting someone from your group to act as chair. Agree beforehand who will do this.

It is the chair's job to:

- Keep the meeting on topic
- Make sure people get a chance to have their say
- Let people know that their contribution is needed and valuable (so don't close off discussion too quickly)

Make sure the atmosphere of the meeting is as welcoming and open as possible.

Don't let the discussion go off on a tangent or get bogged down in little details, stop people once they have had a say. Don't let one or two people dominate.

TAKE MINUTES

Decide who will be taking minutes before the meeting. It is hard to take minutes and chair, so these roles should be done by different people. The minutes of your meeting don't have to be very detailed, but they should include a clear note of any decisions made at the meeting, and in particular who has agreed to take on which jobs.

GATHER NAMES AND ADDRESSES

Make sure you take contact details from everyone who wants to be kept in touch with the group – prepare a sheet in advance which you can pass round the meeting or have on a table at the door.

HAVE A PLAN FOR YOUR NEXT MEETING

Make sure you have already fixed a date and venue for your group's next meeting, and that you advertise this so that people can come along if they want to. It is useful to distribute some fliers with future meeting and contact details, for people to take home.

Source: <https://www.resourcecentre.org.uk/information/the-agenda/>

ARE YOU READY?

How do you know if you have created a well-rounded park committee? The ‘Organization Readiness Checklist’ on the following few pages list the types of people and organizations you need in order to build a park. Read the list. Check the box when you identify those people in your committee. Checking each box ensures your organization is ready to move on to the next chapter.

ORGANIZATION CHECKLIST

The most important aspect of organizing is to prove to yourself that you can orchestrate all that is needed for a neighborhood park. Complete the checklist to see if there are any gaps in your group’s organization that you still need to address to ensure you can do all that is needed for a successful project.

	✓	✗
Have you formed a committee of dedicated neighbors to guide the overall park planning efforts?	☐	☐
Does your organization have financial standing or line-of-credit to support park-related costs, such as property acquisition, maintenance, events, etc.	☐	☐
Does your organization have the ability to raise funds necessary to sustain financial support for the park?	☐	☐
Does your organization have the ability to generate neighborhood interest, organize events and other community engagement activities?	☐	☐
Does your organization have access to a variety of skills and experience, such as carpenters, masons, or other trades- who can offer their knowledge and experience during park construction and maintenance?	☐	☐
Has your organization held initial meetings and community events to generate support and consensus for a potential park ?	☐	☐
Has your organization formed an online page for messaging, announcements and more on Facebook, Instagram or other social media platforms? Does it feature a unique hashtag to identify and brand your park project (eg “#UptownCommunityPark)?	☐	☐